

1947–1962

A GOOD COAT

Not for several decades had the coat been as important for women as it was in the years after World War II. Uniforms influenced fashion, especially the military trench coat, which was adopted for civilian wear as much by women as by men. This popular trend was bolstered by Hollywood screen queens: Marlene Dietrich, Lauren Bacall, Ingrid Bergman, Ava Gardner, and Katharine Hepburn all famously wore trenches in films during this period, to glamorous effect. The right coat was a key element for achieving a polished, “tied-together” look. It was vital that the outer garment was just long enough to cover the hem of the dress or skirt underneath. As wartime restrictions on the buying and tailoring of materials were lifted, coats became ever more luxurious. Furs, in particular, took off and for many women a mink coat was the ultimate status symbol of the era.



1951

Winter warmer Made from a thick wool cloth, this belted coat was a sensible choice for women during the 1950s. The tied belt draws the coat in at the waist to give a full-skirted silhouette that reflects dress shapes of the time.



1952

Short cape German model and winner of Miss World 1956, Petra Shurmann wears a smart ensemble of skirt, jacket, and cape from the department store Defaka. Her matching red gloves, hat, and handbag complete the outfit.

Hourglass shape Following Christian Dior's New Look of 1947, there was a change in the female silhouette, seen to some extent in these coats made the same year. They are sculpted to fit the body and sharply define the waist.

1947

Shoulders still broad

Fur accessories are “in”

